

SWINGING SIXTIES TO GLAM ROCK

The fashion revolution of the 1960s changed the way that women dressed. There was a seismic shift towards youth – dubbed a “youthquake” – and women were no longer expected to dress in middle-aged, tweedy suits as soon as they grew up. Young London designers led the way and took their funky fashions to the US. “Paraphernalia”, a new boutique in New York, sold British modes, with branches opening across the American states. Society was becoming less formal with the invention of the contraceptive pill as reflected in the phrase “The Permissive Society”. The new mood in fashion was slowly changing the more traditional areas of society: famously, model Jean Shrimpton attended the Gold Cup horse race in Australia in 1965, an annual society event, wearing a skirt 12.5 cm (5 in) above the knee.

Bright new future

The swinging sixties was a time of optimism and belief in the future – with the development of Concorde in Britain and France aeroplanes travelled faster than the speed of sound, and the space race between the US and the USSR reached a climax when US astronauts stepped onto the surface of the moon. This dynamism and modernity were mirrored in fashion at all levels, from the energetic action shots of new British fashion photographers such as John Cowan and David Bailey to the metallic and plastic fabrics used by French designers including Michele Rosier and Paco Rabanne.

Counter culture

With the continuing war in Vietnam, the Watergate scandal in the US, and the three-day week in Britain, the bright optimism fizzled out as the sixties became the seventies. An impetus to go “back to nature” was reflected in the nostalgic romanticism of Laura Ashley printed-cotton dresses and colourful, hand-knit garments by designers such as Kaffe Fassett. Fashion entered a fantasy era from glam rock through to ethnically inspired collections such as Yves Saint Laurent’s Chinese and Russian collections and Kenzo Takada’s bright prints. Opting out became most extreme towards the end of the 1970s when entrepreneur Malcolm McLaren, inspired by American groups such as the New York Dolls, formed British punk band the Sex Pistols. The group wore ripped and torn T-shirts with curt slogans such as “Destroy” and “Anarchy”.

1964	1965	1966	
1964 Young designers, including Mary Quant and André Courrèges, introduce the miniskirt and minidress. ► A-line minidress 		1966 By early 1966 the waistline disappears, and designers like Norman Norell showcase loose-fitting dresses with loose sleeves.	
1964 Maija Isola designs the iconic Unikko (poppy) print for Finnish fashion firm Marimekko. 	1965 Yves Saint Laurent's Mondrian-inspired colour blocks sweep through the international fashion world. ► Mondrian's Tableau No. IV, 1924 		
	1965 Young fashion designers, including Foale and Tuffin and Mary Quant, go on the British “Youthquake” tours to the US arranged by the Puritan Fashion Corporation and J.C. Penney in New York.	1966 Twiggy, the “face of ‘66” and one of the world’s first supermodels, shoots to fame.	
1964 The first Biba shop, inspiration of designer Barbara Hulanicki, opens in London, selling young, creative styles at budget prices. ▼ Barbara Hulanicki in her newly opened boutique 		1966 Jewellery designer Paco Rabanne causes a sensation when he launches his linked chain and plastic paillettes minidresses in Paris. ◀ “Experimental” plastic and metal dress by Rabanne 	